Three years ago, when Sushmita Sen signed on to headline the first season of Ram Madhvani's *Aarya*, she was stepping in front of the camera after five years. Playing a mother holding her family together in the wake of a family tragedy in her web series debut demanded that the actress tower over everyone else. Looking at the show, it would be hard to discern that the actor had been away for all these years—Sen turned in a career-defining performance as Aarya Sareen, straddling the varying facets of the female identity with clarity and conviction. At the time, *Aarya* felt like a long overdue course correction for the acting prowess of Sushmita Sen, an actor who has remained underutilised by Hindi cinema for decades.

In 2023, Sen returned with her second web series that seems to underline that *Aarya* might have just been the start. There is no *Taali*, the six-episode biographical series about Shreegauri Sawant, the transgender activist and petitioner in the landmark 2014 case where the Supreme Court declared transgender as the third gender, without Sushmita Sen. The show revolves, in many ways, around Sawant's cult of personality—her strong-willed determination but also her gentle femininity. It's the exact reason that Arjun Singgh Baran and Kartk D. Nishandar, the show's creators, thought of Sen for the role. They were certain that the actor would bring a certain authority to the role without losing the essence of Sawant's womanhood. It helped that like Sen, Sawant is a single mother too—the first transgender woman to adopt a child in India.

On her part, Sen knew that she wanted to do the role the minute she read the script, especially when National Award-winning filmmaker Ravi Jadhav came on board to direct the series. But it took the actor almost six months to sign on the dotted line, time that she took to memorise the screenplay inside out and extensively research about Sawant to absorb the weight of the character. "I believe two things are of utmost importance when I choose to sign on any project—substance and authenticity. And it only makes sense for a character to have that as well. Stories like *Taali* make you reflect on your individual choices and give you assurance [as an actor]," Sen tells INDIA TODAY.

Once the actor was on board, Jadhav and she were certain about one thing—they didn't want Sen's portrayal of Sawant to be played up to a point that it felt like she was mimicking her. "We wanted to maintain authenticity, so we decided to stay away from prosthetics." The team instead relied on hair and make-up to get the look as close as possible. During the entire shooting, Sen remained invested in getting the little details right, like capturing the exact reaction of a man who just underwent a sex operation and wears a bra for the first time.

As challenging as the three-year-long journey to make the show was, the prep stopped feeling challenging to Sen once she met Sawant in person. "When we first met, I knew we would connect instantly," she says. "We had so many things in common—our journey, our values and opinions and, more importantly, the

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